

SHUTTERSTOCK

Salcete, South Goa

You think you're all Goa-ed out? Well, think again, as the state has a lot more than partying on the beach to offer. While the beaches are risky in the rains, the backwaters and mangroves are the perfect places for a peaceful holiday communing with nature. Head to Salcete, where the Sal, perhaps the state's smallest river, meanders magically through villages with the most enchanting names—Nuvem, Seraulim, Colva, Benaulim, Navelim, Orlim, Chinchinim, Cavelossim, Mobor and Betul—until it meets the Arabian Sea. Traipse the Sal backwaters on a kayak or try a stand-up paddle board if you're more adventurous and athletic.

DO Stop by the scenic and secluded São Jacinto Island in Marmagao, where a number of films have been picturised. See the beautiful church, admire the colourful homes, but don't step on local toes

EAT Meat and seafood in authentic Goan gravies such as *xacuti*, *recheado* and *cafreal* at Martin's Corner in Betalbatim, *sannas* and *sorpotel* at Chef Fernando's Nostalgia in Raia

STAY Salcete Beach Resort

GO Well-connected by air

Bastar, Chhattisgarh

With dense, unspoilt forests and the most picturesque cascades, this tribal belt also happens to be part of the red corridor of the Naxalites. Nevertheless, it's been one of our go-to destinations in many seasons. The Chitrakote Falls on the Indravati River—horseshoe-shaped and the widest in India—will remind you of the Niagara Falls, but minus the commercialisation. Expect pristine forest, perfect weather, and the most pose-worthy natural backdrop. The Kailash and Kotumsar caves are closed during the monsoon but are interesting spots to visit in other seasons. The sprawling Bastar Palace in Jagdalpur is an all-season attraction for history buffs, with displays that showcase the armour and clothing of the erstwhile Kakatiya royals, whose descendants still live here.

DO Of the many falls in this region, Tirathgarh is a wonderful place to actually stand under the sheet of water and experience the thundering power of nature

EAT Steamed rice dumplings called *muthia*, *aamat* made in bamboo shoots, and that quintessential monsoon treat–*bhajiyas* (deep-fried onion fritters)

STAY Bastar Jungle Resort

GO Fly to Raipur and drive 316 km



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